

PREFACE: A GUIDING HAND WITH A LIGHT TOUCH



Are you standing in a bookstore by the personal finance shelves, trying to decide which book to buy? There they are, the lot of them, in their important-type jackets, all more or less proclaiming Six Infallible Rules That Will Make You a Millionaire.

So how is this book different?

First, it's fallible. When it comes to the stock market, there are no cinches. The stories in this book cover a quarter of a century of my life on the mutual fund battlefield. I've done well enough to survive with honor, but I've made my share of mistakes along the way. Some of the mistakes are recounted herein. I think you learn at least as much from screwups as you do from successes.

Second, there are plenty of ideas in this book. Many books are based on a couple of decent ideas that could be expressed on one sheet of paper but have been blown up into a \$24.95 book. I've written a hundred quarterly reports to shareholders of the Acorn Fund and tried to put an original idea in every one of them. You'll find a bunch of those ideas here.

Third, you might have some fun. At least, that's my intention. Stocks go up and down, but humor is forever.